## 1.5 NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC EXPLORER DONALD SLATER




Slater studies gravestones like this one from 1729. Its imagery is softened by daisy wheels, spiritually protective symbols.

# Graveyards, Buildings, and American Identity

**"Archaeology is an adventure. Even graveyards and buildings have exciting tales to tell."** —Donald Slater

When **Donald Slater** was growing up in Massachusetts, his parents drove him to a swim club during the summer. On the way, they passed an old graveyard that always caught his eye. It stood abandoned and disordered, with gravestones tilted every which way—some nearly falling over. "I knew there was a story there," Slater remembers thinking. Years later, he became an archaeologist and decided to uncover the stories at such sites himself.

^ Donald Slater enjoys providing students with hands-on archaeological experience. Here, Slater (far left), his colleagues, and students work at a dig at the Rebecca Nurse Homestead to learn about Nurse, who was believed to be a witch and hanged in 1692.



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**MAIN IDEA** Archaeologist Donald Slater investigates colonial New England graveyards and architecture to learn about American culture.

## THE GRAVE WHISPERER

National Geographic Explorer Donald Slater studies graveyards from the 1600s and 1700s. Luckily for him, he lives in New England where there are lots of graveyards from these periods. One of his favorites is the Old Burying Ground, established in 1634 in Ipswich, Massachusetts. It contains the region's oldest documented gravestones, including those of the wife and child of John Winthrop, Jr., the town's chief founder.

As Slater examines a graveyard, he pays particular attention to the iconography of the gravestones—the stone's carved design. Although the details are hotly debated among scholars, Slater believes that changes in the designs point to evolving religious ideas in the New England Colonies. A death's head, showing a stylized skull with wings or crossed bones, appeared on most early gravestones. As the 18th century progressed, however, death's heads were replaced by winged cherub, or angel, heads.

Slater believes a religious movement that began in the 1720s caused the graveyard iconography to soften. The movement—called the Great Awakening—which you'll learn more about later in this chapter, emphasized the idea that people could ascend to heaven by demonstrating their faith in God. Earlier Puritan beliefs held that people's place after death—heaven or hell—was predestined, or determined, by God at birth.

Around the same time, the epitaphs, or inscriptions, carved on the gravestones also became more hopeful. Instead of focusing on mortality, later epitaphs celebrate the deceased's reward in heaven for a life well lived. Some provide a brief narrative of the person's life. According to Slater, one such epitaph reveals that the man buried was born a slave but died free.

## OUR AMERICAN IDENTITY

Like gravestones, colonial architectural styles also evolved over time. Some of these changes reflect cultural change—and the increasing American identity of the colonies. In the early 1600s, builders



Slater reads a gravestone at the South Parish Burial Ground in Andover, Massachusetts. Established in 1709, the cemetery is Andover's oldest museum.

in New England based their structures on English architecture. But instead of brick, the colonists most often used wood and other rustic building materials, which resulted in a uniquely American style. Builders adapted structures to conditions in the colony. For example, they constructed summer kitchens at the rear of a house to avoid heating up the entire home, applying construction techniques they used in England.

Much of New England is a treasure trove of colonial sites and artifacts. But what if you don't live there? Slater suggests you visit your local historical society to learn about early American sites in your community, including those of Native Americans, or ask your neighborhood librarian for information. All these sources can help you discover your American identity. And Slater believes this is important. For, as he says, "There is no better way to preserve our cultural heritage than to educate today's youth on the subject, because it is they who will be making tomorrow's decisions that will determine whether sites are protected or destroyed."

### HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What does Slater study when he investigates colonial graveyards?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** According to Slater, why might a cherub head have replaced the death's head on later graves?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** What do you think the architectural developments by the early 1700s suggest about New England colonists?



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